on to Deoti, where the rest of Hemu's baggage train was camped. More bounty fell to the Mughals, and also, more tragically, Hemu's eighty-year-old father. Pir Muhammad offered him his life in return for converting to Islam, but after eight decades of having 'worshipped my God according to [my own] religion' the old man was not inclined to change. 'Why should I change it at this time,' he said, 'and . . . merely from fear of my life, and without understanding it come into your way of worship?'[48]

Pir Muhammad was not a man to be diverted by theological debate. Hemu's father was killed.

Hajji Khan, meanwhile, arrived in Ajmer, and took it.

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The story of Hajji Khan is one of hundreds of digressions that flow like rivulets from the long-flowing river that is Akbar's life. Not every stream is worth paddling into, and Hajji Khan, though evidently an able commander, might have been safely ignored if his story did not introduce a far more significant character into Akbar's world.

In 1547, a decade earlier, the raja of the Kachhwaha Rajputs had died, leaving behind two embattled sons, Bihari Mal – or Bharmal – and Askaran. It was Hajji Khan, governor of the region, who negotiated a compromise and divided the land between them. The fall of the Suris and Humayun's return brought about a predictable slide in Hajji Khan's fortunes; he lost his territories. When Humayun died, the khan lost no time in winning back his land. Thus it was that Hajji Khan besieged a Mughal commander called Majnun Khan Qaqshal in Narnaul, with Bihari Mal by his side.

It was a tricky situation for the Rajput king, having to choose between a once-powerful Afghan governor and a rising Mughal star, but he managed to keep his bridges intact long enough to pick the right side.[49] Bihari Mal negotiated Majnun Khan Qaqshal's surrender, sending him back to court safe and sound; and, when Hajji Khan fled to Ajmer, his Rajput ally returned Narnaul to the Mughals, too.

Thus, Bihari Mal gained the Mughals' gratitude without arousing Hajji Khan's enmity, and when Akbar arrived in Delhi from Panipat, the Kachhwaha chief was among the elite invited to meet and congratulate him.

Some days later, having established diplomatic relations with the young